# Cambridge IGCSE™

**FIRST LANGUAGE ENGLISH** **0500/02**

Paper 2 Directed Writing and Composition **For examination from 2027**

MARK SCHEME

Maximum Mark: 80

**Converted**

This mark scheme accompanies a converted question paper: Cambridge IGCSE First Language English 0500/21 May/June 2025, restructured to the 2027–2029 Paper 2 format. The reading texts in the insert are unchanged.

Question 1(b) is the source directed writing task, rescaled from 15 reading + 25 writing to 10 reading + 25 writing; its indicative content is transferred unchanged. Question 1(a) is new to this conversion and its indicative content has been written for it. Section B is unchanged.

Level descriptor tables are reproduced from the official 2027 specimen mark scheme (0500/02/SP/27).



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## Generic Marking Principles

All examiners must apply these general marking principles when marking candidate responses. Examiners must apply them alongside the specific content of the mark scheme or generic level descriptions for a question. Each question paper and mark scheme must also comply with these marking principles.

**GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 1:**

Marks must be awarded in line with:

- the specific content of the mark scheme or the generic level descriptions for the question
- the specific skills defined in the mark scheme or in the generic level descriptions for the question
- the standard of response required by a candidate as exemplified by the standardisation scripts.

**GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 2:**

Marks awarded are always whole marks (not half marks, or other fractions).

**GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 3:**

Marks must be awarded positively:

- marks are awarded for correct/valid answers, as defined in the mark scheme. However, credit is given for valid answers which go beyond the scope of the syllabus and mark scheme, referring to your Team Leader as appropriate
- marks are awarded when candidates clearly demonstrate what they know and can do
- marks are not deducted for errors
- marks are not deducted for omissions
- answers should only be judged on the quality of spelling, punctuation and grammar when these features are specifically assessed by the question as indicated by the mark scheme. The meaning, however, should be unambiguous.

**GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 4:**

Rules must be applied consistently, e.g. in situations where candidates have not followed instructions or in the application of generic level descriptions.

**GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 5:**

Marks should be awarded using the full range of marks defined in the mark scheme for the question (however, the use of the full mark range may be limited according to the quality of the candidate responses seen).

**GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 6:**

Marks awarded are based solely on the requirements as defined in the mark scheme. Marks should not be awarded with grade thresholds or grade descriptions in mind.

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## English & Media-Specific Marking Principles

*(To be read in conjunction with the Generic Marking Principles (and requiring further guidance on how to place marks within levels))*

**Components using level descriptions:**

- We use level descriptions as a guide to broad understanding of the qualities normally expected of, or typical of, work in a level.
- Level descriptions are a means of general guidance, and should not be interpreted as hurdle statements.
- Where indicative content notes are supplied for a question, these are not a prescription of required content, and must not be treated as such. Alternative correct points and unexpected answers in candidates' scripts must be given marks that fairly reflect the knowledge and skills demonstrated.
- While we may have legitimate expectations as to the ground most answers may occupy, we must at all times be prepared to meet candidates on their chosen ground, provided it is relevant ground (e.g. clearly related to and derived from a relevant passage/text and meeting the mark scheme requirements for the question).

**Components using point-based marking:**

Point marking is often used to reward knowledge, understanding and application of skills. We give credit where the candidate's answer shows relevant knowledge, understanding and application of skills in answering the question. We do not give credit where the answer shows confusion.

From this it follows that we:

a DO credit answers which are worded differently from the mark scheme if they clearly convey the same meaning (unless the mark scheme requires a specific term).

b DO credit alternative answers/examples which are not written in the mark scheme if they are correct.

c DO credit answers where candidates give more than one correct answer in one prompt/numbered/scaffolded space where extended writing is required rather than list-type answers. For example, questions that require n reasons (e.g. State two reasons …).

d DO NOT credit answers simply for using a 'key term' unless that is all that is required. (Check for evidence it is understood and not used incorrectly.)

e DO NOT credit answers which are obviously self-contradicting or trying to cover all possibilities.

f DO NOT give further credit for what is effectively repetition of a correct point already credited unless the language itself is being tested. This applies equally to 'mirror statements' (i.e. polluted/not polluted).

g DO NOT require spellings to be correct, unless this is part of the test. However spellings of syllabus terms must allow for clear and unambiguous separation from other syllabus terms with which they may be confused (e.g. Corrasion/Corrosion).

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**Notes on this converted mark scheme**

**Question 1(a) is generated.** The 2027 Paper 2 assesses R4, which the source paper did not, so nothing maps to 1(a) from the original mark scheme. The question was tested for answerability against Text A alone before its indicative content was written, and it is anchored to paragraph 3 (lines 18–21).

**Question 1(b) mark change.** Reading falls from 15 to 10; writing is unchanged at 25. The task, the bullets, the word count and the indicative reading content are unchanged.

**Insert length.** The two texts run to 748 words, above the 650-word guide for the 2027 Paper 2 insert. The insert has deliberately not been trimmed, because cutting it would break the line references used in 1(a).

**Table substitutions.** Table A is the specimen Paper 2 Table A, generalised from the named speaker in the specimen task to ‘the writer’. Tables B, C, D and E are reproduced unchanged.

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Note: All Examiners are instructed that alternative correct answers and unexpected approaches in candidates' scripts must be given marks that fairly reflect the relevant knowledge and skills demonstrated. Nonetheless, the content must be clearly related to and derived from the passage.

## Section A: Directed Writing

### Question 1

Question 1(a) tests the following reading assessment objectives (5 marks):

R3 analyse, evaluate and develop facts, ideas and opinions, using appropriate support from the text

R4 demonstrate understanding of how writers achieve effects and influence readers.

Question 1(b) tests the following reading assessment objectives (10 marks):

R1 demonstrate understanding of explicit meanings

R2 demonstrate understanding of implicit meanings and attitudes

R3 analyse, evaluate and develop facts, ideas and opinions, using appropriate support from the text

R5 select and use information for specific purposes.

This question also tests the following writing assessment objectives (25 marks):

W1 articulate experience and express what is thought, felt and imagined

W2 organise and structure facts, ideas and opinions for effect

W3 use a range of vocabulary and sentence structures appropriate to context

W4 use language appropriate to purpose and to engage the audience

W5 make accurate use of spelling, punctuation and grammar.

### Overview of items for Question 1

| Item | Assessment objectives tested | Marks for assessment objectives |
|---|---|---|
| 1(a) | R3 and R4 *(generated)* | 5 |
| 1(b) | R1, R2, R3 and R5 | 10 |
| 1(b) | W1, W2, W3, W4 and W5 | 25 |
| **Total** | | **40** |

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| Question | Answer | Marks |
|---|---|---|
| 1(a) | **Reread this extract from Text A:**<br><br>**'And while we'll try to offer some choice in the settings where students can volunteer, they won't be able to avoid it. They can't choose not to do maths and as another, equally important part of the school curriculum, they won't be able to opt out of volunteering.'**<br><br>**Use your own words to evaluate the headteacher's attitude to making volunteering compulsory. Give details from the text to justify your answer.**<br><br>Use the Marking Criteria for Question 1(a) (Table A, Reading).<br><br>Relevant ideas might include:<br>• treats the matter as already settled: the flat repetition of 'they won't be able to avoid it' and 'they won't be able to opt out' states the policy twice as a future certainty rather than a proposal, leaving no opening for objection<br>• offers only a token concession: 'while we'll try to offer some choice' grants flexibility over *where* students go, which the rest of the sentence immediately withdraws over *whether* they go at all — and the hedging 'try to' weakens even that much<br>• asserts parity with academic subjects rather than arguing for it: the maths comparison borrows the authority of a core timetabled subject, and the appositive 'another, equally important part of the school curriculum' presents that equality as a given<br>• assumes the reader already agrees: 'Of course' opens the paragraph and the breezy aside 'Teachers have enough work and responsibilities, after all!' disposes of a contested staffing question with an exclamation mark instead of a reason<br>• paternalistic but well intentioned: compulsion is framed as something done for the students, who must 'learn to navigate their own way through', so the absence of choice is presented as the educational point rather than as administrative convenience | 5 |

**Table A, Reading**

Use the following table to give a mark out of 5 for Reading. This question tests assessment objectives R3 and R4.

| Level | Marks | Description |
|---|---|---|
| 3 | 4–5 | Clear understanding of the writer's attitude with relevant support from the text. (R3, R4) |
| 2 | 2–3 | Some understanding of the writer's attitude with some supporting detail. (R3, R4) |
| 1 | 1 | Limited understanding of the writer's attitude. (R3, R4) |
| 0 | 0 | No creditable content. |

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| Question | Answer | Marks |
|---|---|---|
| 1(b) | **Write an article for your school or college magazine about whether or not a volunteer scheme for older students would be a good idea.**<br><br>**In your article you should:**<br>• **evaluate the ideas, attitudes and opinions about volunteering in both texts**<br>• **consider the effects a compulsory volunteering scheme in school would have on students, teachers and the wider community.**<br><br>**Base your article on what you have read in both texts, but be careful to use your own words. Address both of the bullet points.**<br><br>**Write about 250 to 350 words.**<br><br>**Up to 10 marks are available for reading and up to 25 marks for writing.**<br><br>**Notes on task:**<br><br>Responses might use the following explicit ideas:<br><br>**Text A**<br>• the previous scheme was unpopular<br>• there are aspects missing in young people's lives – compassion, service<br>• will need vetted settings<br>• will be unsupervised / cannot opt out<br>• volunteering should have parity with other subjects<br>• time will need to be found in the curriculum<br><br>**Text B**<br>• volunteering means giving up time/many people do this informally<br>• resentful students do not make good volunteers<br>• adults can choose how and where to volunteer<br>• modern charity workers are paid and trained<br>• learning to help at home might be more valuable | 35 |

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| Question | Answer | Marks |
|---|---|---|
| 1(b) | **Possible evaluation of ideas:**<br><br>• learning independence is valuable for students' futures.<br>• compulsory volunteering is contradictory / misses its real value. (Do not accept 'it shouldn't be compulsory' on its own.)<br>• teachers will have less time to teach the curriculum / could ease their workload (Both valid inferences)<br>• admin of checking placements is difficult, time-consuming<br>• academics should not be jeopardised / may impact students' achievement<br>• students do not have the maturity to help vulnerable people/too much responsibility for young people/could do harm<br>• charity workers will look after students, not the people who need care<br>• a bad experience might put students off charity work for life<br>• may lead to careers in charity organisations | |

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## Marking criteria for Section A Question 1(b)

### Table B, Writing

Use the following table to give a mark out of 25 for writing.

| Level | Marks | Description |
|---|---|---|
| 6 | 22–25 | • Highly effective style capable of conveying subtle meaning. (W1)<br>• Carefully structured for benefit of the reader. (W2)<br>• Purposefully selected vocabulary, precisely used. (W3)<br>• Highly effective use of language for audience and purpose. (W4)<br>• Spelling, punctuation and grammar almost always accurate. (W5) |
| 5 | 18–21 | • Effective style. (W1)<br>• Secure overall structure, organised to help the reader. (W2)<br>• Well-chosen vocabulary, used with some precision. (W3)<br>• Effective use of language for audience and purpose. (W4)<br>• Spelling, punctuation and grammar mostly accurate, with occasional minor errors. (W5) |
| 4 | 14–17 | • Sometimes effective style. (W1)<br>• Ideas generally well sequenced. (W2)<br>• Uses a range of appropriate vocabulary. (W3)<br>• Sometimes effective use of language for audience and purpose. (W4)<br>• Spelling, punctuation and grammar generally accurate though with some errors. (W5) |
| 3 | 10–13 | • Inconsistent style, expression sometimes awkward but meaning clear. (W1)<br>• Relies on the sequence of the original text. (W2)<br>• Vocabulary is simple, limited in range or reliant on the original text. (W3)<br>• Some awareness of audience and purpose. (W4)<br>• Frequent errors of spelling, punctuation and grammar, sometimes affecting communication. (W5) |
| 2 | 6–9 | • Limited style. (W1)<br>• Limited evidence of sequencing. (W2)<br>• Limited vocabulary or words/phrases copied from the original text. (W3)<br>• Limited awareness of audience and purpose. (W4)<br>• Persistent errors of spelling, punctuation and grammar, occasionally impeding communication. (W5) |
| 1 | 1–5 | • Expression unclear. (W1)<br>• Very limited sequencing of ideas. (W2)<br>• Very limited vocabulary or copying from the original text. (W3)<br>• Very limited awareness of audience and purpose. (W4)<br>• Persistent errors in spelling, punctuation and grammar impede communication. (W5) |
| 0 | 0 | No creditable content. |

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**Table C, Reading**

Use the following table to give a mark out of 10 for reading.

| Level | Marks | Description |
|---|---|---|
| 5 | 9–10 | • A wide range of ideas is applied. (R1, R2)<br>• Develops ideas and opinions. (R3)<br>• Integrates ideas from the text(s) to give a convincing response. (R5) |
| 4 | 7–8 | • A good range of ideas is evident. (R1, R2)<br>• Some development of ideas and opinions. (R3)<br>• Some ideas supported by details from the text(s). (R5) |
| 3 | 5–6 | • A range of straightforward ideas is offered. (R1, R2)<br>• Opportunities for development of ideas and opinions are rarely taken. (R3)<br>• Includes some detail but there may be some mechanical use of the text(s). (R5) |
| 2 | 3–4 | • Some brief, straightforward reference to explicit ideas and opinions. (R1, R2)<br>• Recognises some of the main ideas and opinions. (R3)<br>• There may be some reliance on lifting from the text(s). (R5) |
| 1 | 1–2 | • Limited response with little reference to the text(s), or a reproduction of sections of the original(s). (R1, R2)<br>• Limited response to the topic of the text(s). (R3)<br>• Content is either insubstantial or unselective. (R5) |
| 0 | 0 | No creditable content. |

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## Section B: Composition

### Questions 2, 3, 4 and 5

The question tests the following writing objectives (40 marks):

W1 articulate experience and express what is thought, felt and imagined

W2 organise and structure facts, ideas and opinions for effect

W3 use a range of vocabulary and sentence structures appropriate to context

W4 use language appropriate to purpose and to engage the audience

W5 make accurate use of spelling, punctuation and grammar.

| Question | Answer | Marks |
|---|---|---|
| 2 | **EITHER — Write a description with the title, 'The shelter'.**<br><br>Use Table D to give a mark out of 16 for content and structure and Table E to give a mark out of 24 for style and accuracy. | 40 |
| 3 | **OR — Describe a time when you had to wait for a delivery.**<br><br>Use Table D to give a mark out of 16 for content and structure and Table E to give a mark out of 24 for style and accuracy. | 40 |
| 4 | **OR — Write a story which includes the words, '… it could not be stopped … '.**<br><br>Use Table D to give a mark out of 16 for content and structure and Table E to give a mark out of 24 for style and accuracy. | 40 |
| 5 | **OR — Write a story with the title, 'The path to success'.**<br><br>Use Table D to give a mark out of 16 for content and structure and Table E to give a mark out of 24 for style and accuracy. | 40 |

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## Marking criteria for Section B

### Table D, Composition: Content and structure

| Level | Marks | Description |
|---|---|---|
| 6 | 14–16 | • **General** — Content is highly focused on the task, complex and engaging. (W1) Structure is secure, well balanced and carefully managed for deliberate effect. (W2)<br>• **Descriptive** — Creates well-defined and developed ideas and images in response to the prompt to offer a convincing overall picture. Uses features of descriptive writing such as close observation, effective use of figurative language and varieties of focus.<br>• **Narrative** — Crafts a well-defined and strongly developed plot in response to the prompt. Uses features of fiction writing such as description, characterisation and effective climax, with convincing details. |
| 5 | 11–13 | • **General** — Content is well focused on the task, developed and mostly engaging. (W1) Structure is well managed, with some choices made for deliberate effect. (W2)<br>• **Descriptive** — Offers some well-chosen images and details in response to the prompt to give a mostly convincing picture.<br>• **Narrative** — The plot is defined and developed with features of fiction writing such as description, characterisation, climax and details. |
| 4 | 8–10 | • **General** — Content is focused on the task with some development. (W1) Structure is competently managed. (W2)<br>• **Descriptive** — A selection of partially effective ideas, images and details.<br>• **Narrative** — The plot is relevant and cohesive; begins to use features such as characterisation and setting of scene. |
| 3 | 5–7 | • **General** — Content shows some focus on the task, is straightforward and briefly developed. (W1) Structure is mostly organised but may not always be effective. (W2)<br>• **Descriptive** — A series of generally relevant details, with limited use of the features of descriptive writing.<br>• **Narrative** — The plot is straightforward, with limited use of the features of narrative writing. |
| 2 | 3–4 | • **General** — Content lacks focus and is simple; ideas and events may be limited. (W1) Structure is partially organised. (W2)<br>• **Descriptive** — Occasionally relevant with limited detail.<br>• **Narrative** — Events are only partially linked and/or lack clarity. |
| 1 | 1–2 | • **General** — Content is occasionally relevant or clear. (W1) Structure is limited and ineffective. (W2)<br>• **Descriptive** — The description is unclear.<br>• **Narrative** — The narrative lacks coherence. |
| 0 | 0 | No creditable content. |

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**Table E, Composition: Style and accuracy**

| Level | Marks | Description |
|---|---|---|
| 6 | 21–24 | • Precise, well-chosen vocabulary and varied sentence structures, chosen for effect. (W3)<br>• Highly effective use of language to engage the reader. (W4)<br>• Spelling, punctuation and grammar almost always accurate. (W5) |
| 5 | 17–20 | • Mostly precise vocabulary and a range of sentence structures mostly used for effect. (W3)<br>• Effective use of language to engage the reader. (W4)<br>• Spelling, punctuation and grammar mostly accurate, with occasional minor errors. (W5) |
| 4 | 13–16 | • Some precise vocabulary and a range of sentence structures sometimes used for effect. (W3)<br>• Sometimes effective use of language to engage the reader. (W4)<br>• Spelling, punctuation and grammar generally accurate though with some errors. (W5) |
| 3 | 9–12 | • Simple vocabulary and a range of straightforward sentence structures. (W3)<br>• Some awareness of the reader. (W4)<br>• Frequent errors of spelling, punctuation and grammar, sometimes affecting communication. (W5) |
| 2 | 5–8 | • Limited and/or imprecise vocabulary and sentence structures. (W3)<br>• Limited awareness of the reader. (W4)<br>• Persistent errors of spelling, punctuation and grammar, occasionally impeding communication. (W5) |
| 1 | 1–4 | • Frequently imprecise vocabulary and sentence structures. (W3)<br>• Very limited awareness of the reader. (W4)<br>• Persistent errors in spelling, punctuation and grammar impede communication. (W5) |
| 0 | 0 | No creditable content. |

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